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# Advertising in Saudi Arabia: Content and Regulation

Advertising in  
Saudi Arabia

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Recent literature in international marketing reveals a substantial growth of interest in marketing communications with notable emphasis on international advertising. Also receiving much notice is the topic of advertising regulation and content as reflected in the nature of advertising messages and appeals. The increasing attention paid to this area is not without reason (Boddewyn, 1982; Neelankavil and Stridsberg, 1979; Boddewyn and Marton, 1978). Regardless of how aggressive marketers may be in their use of advertising, their ultimate success hinges upon creative ways of matching advertising content with sociocultural norms and legal environments (Peebles and Ryans, 1984; Boddewyn, 1981).

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An abundant literature deals with aspects of advertising regulation in the developed world and some developing countries, but the predominantly conservative Middle East is overlooked. The purpose of this study is partially to fill this void by examining the nature of advertising content and related regulation in Saudi Arabia. Such a study is relevant and significant for several reasons. First, the Saudi market has undergone tremendous transformation within the past few years. Until a decade ago, a seller's market prevailed, and most products received little or no local advertising. Today, however, in order to remain competitive in a buyer's market, companies in Saudi Arabia are investing large sums to launch new products and design new images for existing brands (Tarbush, 1986). Furthermore, comments such as Saudi Arabia "has no media" or "you can't run a proper campaign there" are no longer valid (Graham, 1979). Advertisers now can even make use of television advertising, which was not allowed until 1985.

Second, Saudi Arabia plays a key role in the Gulf Co-operation Council (GCC), an Arabic/Islamic common market which includes Qatar, Kuwait, Oman, United Arab Emirates, Bahrain and Saudi Arabia. Currently, these countries are forging a common consumer and trade policy to ensure economic integration; when completed, it will present formidable marketing opportunities for multinational companies. Because Saudi Arabia is the largest and economically strongest member of the GCC, it will shape significantly the legal regulations which will oversee all commercial activity (including advertising) among the member states. An understanding of advertising regulation in this gateway country thus becomes essential for marketers interested in the region.

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Third, Saudi Arabia can no longer be considered a closed, austere desert society isolated from the West. On the contrary, pockets of Western influence frequently affect local values and practices. As a country in transition, Saudi Arabia presents an opportunity to study how Western-oriented business and advertising practices are being modified to accommodate religious beliefs, traditions and life-styles. Furthermore, to help in its development, Saudi Arabia has drawn upon personnel from many different parts of the world. The expatriates, who number more than two million and constitute 30 per cent of the local population, influence the thinking of the Saudis. In addition, an increasing number of Saudis are exposed to Western values through travel and education (Yavas and Tuncalp, 1985).

### Influences on Advertising

Most of the literature on factors influencing advertising regulations focus either on global standardisation of advertising strategies or specific regulations and their effect on content.

Proponents of standardisation argue that universal appeals are feasible because of converging customer preferences resulting from technology, consumer mobility and international media exposure (Domzal and Unger, 1987; Levitt, 1983; Fatt, 1967; Ellinder, 1961). While external forces contribute to standardisation, their influence on advertising content is less pronounced. Critics of that view emphasise a tailored approach on the premise that environmental factors create significant differences

| External Factors<br>influencing advertising                    | Authors                                                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ● Religion                                                     | Boddewyn 1980; Luqmani, Quraeshi & Delene 1980; Fares 1979; Lenormand 1964                                                                                                          |
| ● Socio-economic conditions                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| — Culture and customs                                          | Amine and Cavusgil, 1983; Boddewyn and Marton, 1978; Dunn, 1976; Green and Cunningham, 1975; Britt, 1974; Klippel and Boewadt, 1974; Lenormand, 1964                                |
| — Economic factors/<br>standard of living                      | Boddewyn, 1982; Boddewyn and Hansen, 1977; Dunn, 1976; Klippel and Boewadt, 1974; Lenormand, 1964.                                                                                  |
| — Nationalism                                                  | Boddewyn 1982; Boddewyn and Hansen 1977; Dunn, 1976                                                                                                                                 |
| ● Consumer orientation                                         | White, 1979; Nagashima, 1977; Boddewyn and Hansen, 1977; Britt, 1974; Ryans, 1969; Schleifer and Dunn, 1968                                                                         |
| — attitudes toward product/<br>country of origin               |                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ● Environment/ecological<br>attitudes                          | Boddewyn, 1982; Dunn, 1976                                                                                                                                                          |
| ● Media infrastructure-<br>characteristics and<br>availability | Rau and Preble, 1987; Kaikati, 1979; Keegan, 1980; Sorenson and Wiechmann, 1975; Dunn, 1976; Miracle, 1968; Lenormand, 1964.                                                        |
| ● Government control/<br>regulatory structure                  | Rau and Preble, 1987; Sethi, 1987; Cateora, 1983; Boddewyn, 1982; Lorimor, 1979; Boddewyn and Marton; 1978; Dunn, 1976; Sorenson & Wiechmann, 1975; Miracle, 1968; Lenormand, 1964. |

**Table I.**  
Factors Influencing  
Advertising Cited by  
Selected Authors

among international consumers (Green and Cunningham, 1980; Dunn, 1976; Donnelly, 1970; Fournis, 1962). Some writers suggest that the extent of standardisation should be determined by such decision criteria as the degree of market homogeneity, product type and availability of media (Ryans, 1969; Miracle, 1968).

A second body of literature examines various regulatory structures, control mechanisms, and their effect on advertising (Boddewyn, 1981; Cohen, 1980; Neelankavil and Stridsberg, 1979; Boddewyn and Marton, 1978). The growing influence of regulation on advertising content is apparent in this research.

As specified in Table I, there is some consensus about the areas which are most influential: (1) religion, (2) socio-economic conditions, (3) consumer orientation, (4) ecological attitudes, (5) media infrastructure, and (6) government control and regulatory structure.

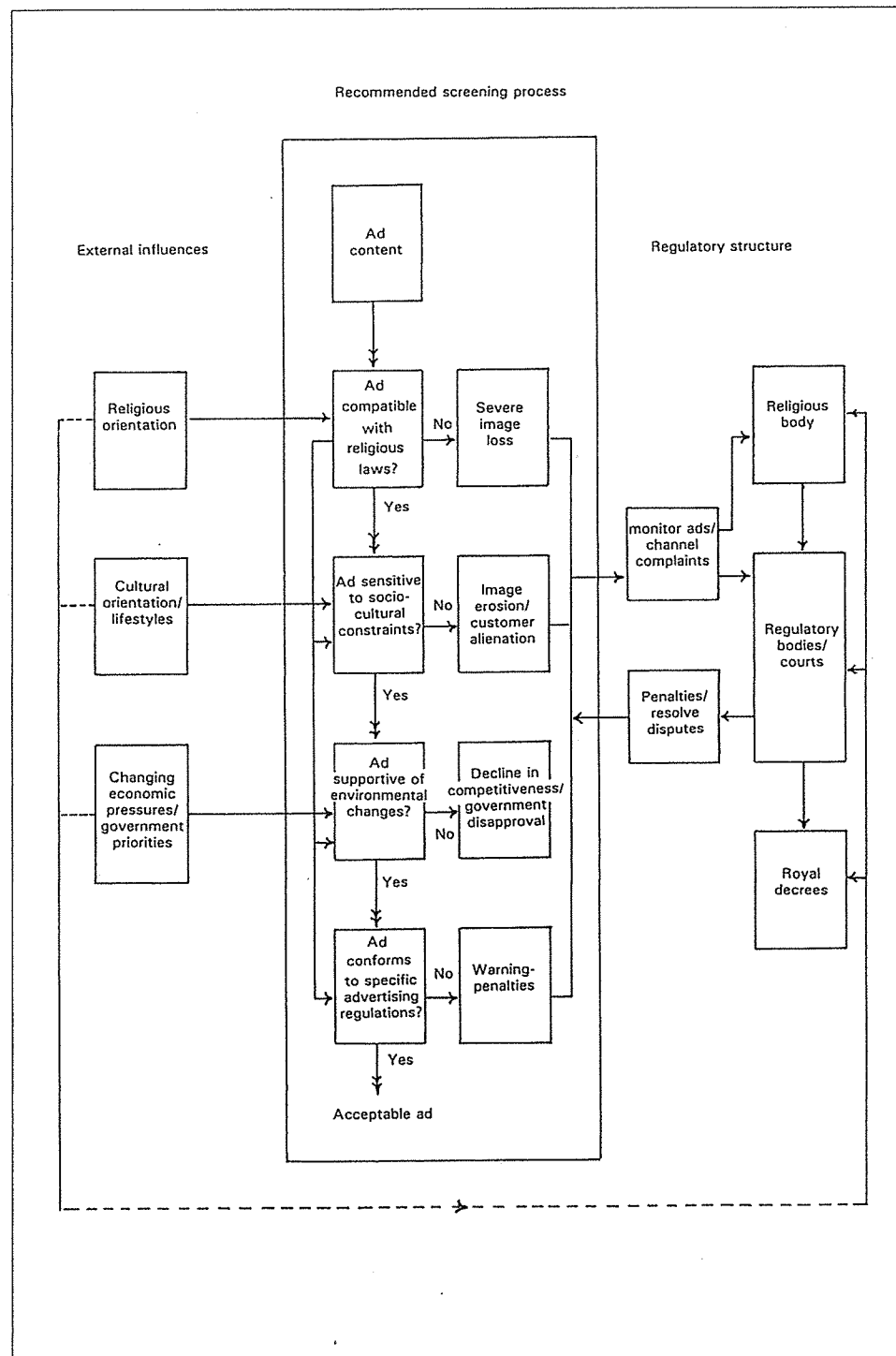
All these factors operate in Saudi Arabia but two predominate. First, religion takes such precedence over all other cultural considerations (Wright, 1981; Anastos, Bedos and Seaman, 1980; Luqmani, Quraeshi, and Delene, 1980; Pezeshkpur, 1978) that it should not be grouped with them (culture, here, refers solely to local customs and traditions), as is the common practice (Cateora, 1983). From an advertising perspective it may be useful to group countries into three categories: (1) religious dominant, such as Saudi Arabia and Iran, (2) culture dominant, with religion as only one among several factors influencing culture, such as Japan and Korea, and (3) nonpartisan, that is, culture and religion have a lesser influence, such as Sweden and Austria.

Second, the Saudi government controls large sectors of the economy, ecology and media infrastructure. Public policies and developmental priorities have a significant effect on business activity and advertising (Graham, 1981; Kaikati, 1979). Factors affecting the content and regulation of advertising in Saudi Arabia can be grouped into three areas: (1) legal environment (derived from religious sources); (2) the socio-economic environment (cultural and economic factors as they affect consumer and company orientation), and (3) government priorities (affecting media infrastructure, ecology, and regulatory change). We will limit our discussion to these three (see Figure 1).

### **The Legal Environment in Saudi Arabia**

The Saudi legal system is unique in the sense that it identifies law with the personal command of the "one and only one God, the Almighty". The Islamic laws known as *sharia* are the master framework to which all legislation, existing and proposed, is referred and with which it must be compatible.

The *sharia* is a comprehensive code governing the duties, morals and behaviour of all Muslims, individually and collectively in all areas of life, including commerce. Sharia is derived from two basic sources, the Quran or Holy Book, and the Hadith, based on the life, sayings, and practices of the Prophet Muhammad. In Western legal terminology, the absolute and irrevocable injunctions in the Quran, are analogous to code laws; the Hadith, which provides added direction on how Quranic injunctions should be put into practice, corresponds to common law. At the very minimum, an understanding of fundamental sharia laws as contained in Quranic injunctions is necessary in order to gain insights into advertising regulation and content (Luqmani, Quraeshi and Delene, 1980).



**Figure 1.**  
Framework of  
Influences on  
Advertising  
Acceptability and  
Content in Saudi Arabia

Three sets of Quranic messages have special significance for advertising regulation. First, there are strict taboos (*haram*), such as alcohol, gambling, cheating, idol worship, usury, adultery and "immodest" exposure. Since these acts are viewed as damaging to the individual and society, they deeply affect the legitimacy and control of advertising. For example, alcoholic products are banned. There are no local ads, and foreign print media are only allowed into the country after all advertisements of alcoholic beverages have been censored. Promotions involving games of chance are illegal. The Ministry of Commerce banned ads featuring sweepstakes in 1983 after a complaint by the Council of Ulema (religious scholars) that these violated Islamic prescriptions against gambling. The protests followed a barrage of lotteries publicised in the local press by car dealers and supermarkets as part of their sales campaigns. Slogans such as, "I won this Mercedes from Juffali" targeted to purchasers of household appliances had to be scrapped (Shehadi, 1984). Accordingly, sweepstakes have been replaced by other promotional tools, particularly contests in which participants win prizes if they answer questions correctly. For example, a distributor of Royal Regina honey capsules successfully ran a contest that included a question on how many times bees are mentioned in the Quran, along with questions and information about the product.

Other dangers for advertisers include messages which may be considered deceptive by religious standards. According to Islam, fraud may occur if the seller fails to deliver everything promised, and advertisers may need to use factual appeals, based on real rather than perceived product benefits. Statuary should not appear in advertising, since it may be perceived as a symbol of idol worship. Since religious norms require women to be covered, international print ads may have to be modified by superimposing long dresses on models or by shading their legs with black. Advertisers of cosmetics in Saudi Arabia refrain from picturing sensuous females; instead, in typical ads a pleasant-looking woman appears in a robe and headdress, with only her face showing. Cartoon characters frequently are used to represent women in ads since these are less likely to violate Islamic codes on exposure.

A second set of Quranic injunctions governs the duties a Muslim must perform, such as praying five times daily, fasting during the month of Ramadhan, giving *zakaat* (charity) to the poor, and respecting and caring for parents and the disadvantaged. Advertisers have to ensure that they do not hinder the performance of these obligations. For example, during the five prayer times, which last from 10 to 20 minutes, products cannot be promoted on radio or TV, retail shops close, and no commercial or official transactions are permitted. Ads should not depict, even humorously, children being disrespectful to parents and elders, whereas the image of a product could be enhanced by ads that stress parental advice or approval. Advertising messages should be prepared so that the most vulnerable groups, including the poor and less educated, are not misled.

A third set of Quranic injunctions remind the faithful of God's bounties and enjoins them to thank Him for such blessings as good health, peace of mind, food, water and children. It is legal and sometimes recommended practice for advertisers to introduce their messages with Quranic words: "In the Name of Allah, the Most

Gracious, the Most Merciful''; ''By the Grace of God''; ''God is Great (Allah-o-Akbar)'''. Al-Rabiah and Nasser, a manufacturer of water pumps, uses a Quranic verse: ''We made from water every living thing''. Such verses also may be used to legitimise operations or to assure that services are in accord with Islamic principles. Banks, for example, cannot pay interest since that is considered usury. Depositors take equity participation in a bank's investment projects, sharing in resultant profits and losses.

### Socio-economic Factors

#### *The Cultural Environment*

The most serious violations are ads that conflict with Islamic law, yet legality does not guarantee approval. Ads may be censored for insensitivity to cultural norms and values. Realising this, such multinationals as Procter and Gamble and Buitoni Pasta have felt it necessary to produce ads in Saudi Arabia. Cultural adaptation of advertising messages among newer entrants to the market is also apparent. Particularly relevant for advertising in the Saudi market are traditions, social patterns and symbolism.

As do many other developing countries, Saudi Arabia strongly adheres to local customs. Age-old traditions continue to be observed in dress, salutations, hospitality and so forth. Although no laws specifically regulate the culture content of ads, insensitivity may destroy credibility. A major tea company alienated Saudi customers after it aired a commercial that showed a Saudi host serving tea with his left hand to one of his guests. Moreover, the guest was wearing shoes while seated, which is considered disrespectful by traditional Saudis.

An important cultural factor with implications for advertising is the dualism of Saudi society. One aspect is highly public. Social events and programmes are heavily publicised. The mass media as well as opinion leaders play an important role in discussing public issues and supporting public programmes. A continuing tradition of open forums allows access to the highest authorities, including audiences with the king. This means that complaints, such as the adverse effects of advertising on Saudi society, are quickly relayed to those responsible for shaping future legislation.

The other side of Saudi life is the intense privacy of family and home (Daniels *et al.*, 1983). Saudis spend much leisure time with close relatives, and outsiders may not intrude on this domain. There is virtually no direct access to family members, who may be reached only indirectly, for example, through radio and television advertising. Videotape commercials are particularly appealing since these can be watched at home, at leisure. Television ads have only been allowed in the last three years, on only one channel, and on a highly restrictive basis. Ads cannot interrupt regular programming and are shown in clusters of ten or fifteen minutes. Reference to violence, unwholesome environments or cigarettes is not permissible. Yet, the Saudis cannot control the content of ads shown on television programmes beamed in from other Gulf states or Egypt, and some international companies are targeting the Saudi and expatriate audience through these media. Due to the influence Saudi Arabia is likely to wield among the GCC countries, however, it can be assumed that the Saudis will have a dominant say in harmonising advertising policies in the region.

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Another proclivity in Saudi culture is themes accenting heritage. For example, the Saudi penchant for poetic symbolism is apparent in the frequent use of Arabic proverbs and poetic phrases. Renault makes effective use of some lines by Al-Mutanabi, a famous Arabic poet: "Because of spending my time with horses and in travelling during the night through the desert, I became known to these three: horses, night, and desert". The three are powerful metaphors for grace, mystery, and majesty. Similarly, ads for Thomas Cook Travellers' Cheques use a famous Arab proverb: "Choose your companion carefully before you travel". Rolex has successfully applied the Arabic sword and oil as symbols of power and development. Consumers are responsive to pictures of indigenous and highly admired animals and birds such as horses, camels and falcons (Tuncalp and Yavas 1986). Ads appreciating Arabic architecture, calligraphy and floral designs also are highly effective.

#### *The Economic Environment*

Meteoric rises in oil prices in the mid-1970s and early 1980s brought unprecedented wealth to Saudi Arabia. A seller's market rapidly emerged as consumers developed a voracious appetite for any and everything for sale. A rapidly expanding expatriate population accelerated demand. There was little need to promote products, media alternatives were limited. Consumers relied on four sources to acquire information on new products: (1) word of mouth from friends and relatives; (2) personal visits to stores and supply houses; (3) dealers and showrooms; (4) ads seen when travelling abroad and a few standardised ads placed by foreign companies in local media. Consumers generally favoured well known brands and producers. Competition was at best complacent although personal selling was used by some dealer organisations to approach customers.

In the heyday of the economic boom, Western oriented ads were effective in lending credibility and status to products. They also appealed to a rapidly emerging, Western-educated elite with a particular affinity for American goods. Having studied in US institutions and returned home to high positions in government at handsome salaries, these graduates became the status group and the innovators in the diffusion of US products. In this milieu, visual advertising was the most common and standardised ads were appealing to the Saudis as long as they did not conflict with religious and cultural values.

It is interesting to note that Japanese ads were similar to Western ones in terms of layout but not content. The harmony of the natural environment, such as the expansive desert, was infused into many Japanese ads, and their focus was more local. For example, the advertisements of US cars used such slogans as "the beautiful world of..." or "the rising star of...", whereas Mazda showed a Saudi holding a winner's cup while stating: "Be the man of the year...Own the car of the year". The representation of various foreign manufacturers by local dealers also influenced the nature and content of advertising. Some of the dealers reproduced foreign ads, while others placed the product in a local setting, but with prominent display of the foreign brand name.

The precipitous decline in oil prices and government spending significantly increased competition among business firms and Saudi Arabia. The result was a

surge in advertising, and big budgets became common. Products required an extra push as the situation changed from a seller's to a buyer's market. The change is reflected in tone and the types of products advertised. Formerly, mostly informative content was used to promote a few luxury and electronics goods. Advertising today is more persuasive and increasingly applies to a broader range of products: soaps and detergents; frozen chicken, and other foodstuffs; mineral water and drinks; insect repellents, and hair tonics. Locally manufactured items such as building materials and chemicals are also heavily promoted on a regular basis.

Advertising strategies have become more aggressive, and buyers are given incentives. Until recently, prices were rarely cited, but price has become a major selling point and discounts are widely advertised. Local supermarkets list weekly specials; clothing stores announce sales; and dealers picture their latest appliances with suggested manufacturer's prices crossed over and lower sales prices written in.

The energetic use of advertising is appearing also in the service sectors, such as banking. Until a few years ago, advertising by banks was infrequent, and messages generally were limited to announcements of new branch openings. Today, Saudi banks use the local media intensively (Habib *et al.*, 1987), and competition has led them to stress their relative advantages. In an advertisement headlined "talk to the bank that understands", the Saudi British Bank accentuates the features of its electronic banking facilities. Saudi Holland Bank emphasises that customers can count on its 60 years in Saudi Arabia. Stating that "Customer Satisfaction is Our Goal", Saudi Cairo Bank points to the numerous differential competitive services it offers.

### **Government Priorities**

The government of Saudi Arabia promulgates new legislation and amendments through royal decrees. The king is considered the protector of the nation and its laws. The commitment of the government to certain causes has influenced the legal system, and areas of particular relevance for advertising include consumer and ecological protection and domestication of business.

### ***Consumer/Ecological Protection***

Two pieces of legislation, both of which are strictly enforced, suggest trends in consumer protection. Both are rationalised as necessary for the safety of consumers. One requires that no car be sold without passing a sophisticated, computerised safety check on forty critical items; this is intended to protect the buyer from serious defects in brakes, tyres, and lighting systems. The other imposes penalties on anyone selling adulterated or spoiled foodstuffs; customer complaints about the continued sale of outdated grocery items have led to the dismissal of otherwise responsible employees. Consumer protection is being given increasing priority, especially in such sensitive areas as safety, health, or possible deception. This attitude dominates Saudi courts and regulators when advertising practices are examined for infractions.

Protection of the consumer is also reflected in restrictions placed on advertisements of products perceived to be injurious to society. For example, cigarette promotion is banned by the Ministry of Health, although newspapers published abroad and containing cigarette ads are not restricted.

Advertising of medicines is also prohibited, a long-standing policy designed to protect a largely illiterate population from possible misuse. The concern may be exaggerated by the government to project the image of a benevolent administration concerned with the health of its citizens.

Previously, advertising of professional services was also banned, but now an exception is made when starting a new practice or medical service. These ads mention the availability of specialised or supportive facilities, such as X-rays and laboratory testing equipment, and no prices are quoted, although individuals and companies are encouraged to take advantage of membership discounts. Recent ads of medical facilities contain information of a routine nature on clinics, physicians, pharmacies, working hours and location. The easing of restrictions is probably a result of the current excess supply of medical services in Saudi Arabia.

Ecological protection is another government priority. "Keep the environment beautiful" is the current theme of many government campaigns. Rules and regulations include heavy fines on individuals and firms if they are judged to be polluting the environment. Critics assail the current high use of outdoor advertising (10 per cent of total ad expenditures), including billboards, guardrails, lamp posts, and bus stop shelters, deploring what they refer to as visual pollution in some areas. Some municipalities have put restrictions on billboard advertising and continued emphasis on the natural beauty theme is likely to limit further the use of outdoor advertising.

### *Domestication*

Efforts are under way to promote Saudi participation in all aspects of business. All organisations, foreign or local, are required to increase their content of local labour, management, production and ownership. This process, coupled with growing nationalism, is changing the content of advertising; more Saudi models are used and there is more emphasis on cultural traditions and the Arabic language and heritage. Previously, many ads were in English, partly because of the lower cost of using standardised ads and partly because a Western-educated elite was targeted. As domestication continues, more ads will have to be localised. Some ad agencies already are creating bilingual ad copy for clients, feeling that this gives the campaign a consistency it would not have if separate English and Arabic versions were developed. This demands creative Arabic copywriting, calligraphy, art and design.

Some companies have been using a mixture of image and advocacy advertising to inform the public and the government of their commitment to help achieve domestication. Fluor Arabia Limited, a member of the Al-Juffali group, recently placed a number of advertisements in both English and Arabic media pointing to its contributions in training locals to facilitate "Saudization".

### Summary

The discussion of factors influencing advertising suggests that ads in Saudi Arabia be designed to be compatible with religious standards, the socio-economic environment and government priorities. Some recommended adjustments are shown in Table II.

**Table II.**  
Adaptation of Western-  
oriented Ads to Saudi  
Audiences

| Elements of advertising | Nature of adaptation/shift                                                                                                                   | Influencing factor                        |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Message length          | Short copy                                                                                                                                   | Cultural/Government restrictions on media |
| Message content         | Emphasise visual aspects; add parental and family themes; avoid perceived product benefits and themes; demonstrate tangible product benefits | Religious                                 |
| Language of message     | Bilingual (English/Arabic)                                                                                                                   | Sociocultural/<br>Government priorities   |
| Symbols                 | Add local symbols; avoid use of statues, busts                                                                                               | Cultural;<br>Religious                    |
| Slogans/jingles         | Use with caution                                                                                                                             | Religious                                 |
| Characters in ads       | Use male and parental figures; substitute women with cartoon characters in sexually sensitive ads                                            | Religious                                 |
| Pictorial backgrounds   | Add landscapes/floral designs                                                                                                                | Socio-economic                            |
| Appeals                 | Increase the use of informational/factual appeals                                                                                            | Socio-economic;<br>Religious              |
| Sexual themes           | Avoid                                                                                                                                        | Religious                                 |
| Humour themes           | Tone down                                                                                                                                    | Cultural                                  |
| Credibility themes      | Increase to establish credibility before competitive/persuasive advertising                                                                  | Socio-economic                            |
| Nature of advertising   | Institutional, image and advocacy advertising                                                                                                | Socio-economic/<br>government priorities  |

### Regulatory Agencies

No specific governmental agency is responsible for controlling advertising behaviour in Saudi Arabia. Also, there is no self-regulatory industry group, and there is no evidence of any effort to develop one. Increasingly, however, companies are involved in self-compliance, that is, individual efforts to meet Saudi norms, which eventually may lead to self-regulation. Possible violations are monitored in two ways. The government is involved through the Ministry of Commerce which ensures that ads remain within legal bounds, and the Ministry of Information which approves television commercials. Less formal oversight is provided by a voluntary religious group, the Organization for the Prevention of Sins and Order of Good Deeds.

Members, called *muttawas*, observe public and commercial behaviour, including promotional materials, for any violations of Islamic law. This organisation works closely with the Ministry of Interior, Information and Commerce in reporting violations and taking corrective action.

Public complaints on major business improprieties are expressed through petitions at a *majless*, an open daily meeting held by the governors and key ministers of various provinces. Petitions approved by the governor's office are then referred to the Commission for the Settlement of Commercial Disputes, a commercial court under the Ministry of Commerce, which designates a Legal Advisor, although the judges are appointed by the Ministry of Justice. The court's decision is based on a system of code laws and royal decrees. Petitions also may be directed to the Sharia High Court, which bases its decision on Islamic law. The rulings are enforced by the Civil Rights Department of various local police stations (Audhali, 1986).

Disciplinary action is also taken when the practices of a company are found to be inconsistent with its advertisements. For example, a meat store that sold postdated food was forced to place and pay for two simultaneous advertisements that ran for several consecutive days. One was its usual ad that highlighted the availability of fresh meat and fish. The other, immediately below the first in bold letters, was an announcement by the Ministry of Commerce that the store had violated the law by offering for sale several cartons of meat with expired dates.

Violations may also bring disciplinary action against the client's advertising agency and placement media. The severe and swift penalties, imposed on all without exception, encourage self-compliance. Advertising agencies play an active part since they are the dominant producers of professional ads (companies with an in-house advertising department are rare). The need for compliance is even more pressing for the leading Saudi agencies, Tihama and Marwah, who as media representatives for several local newspapers and magazines have the dual role of selling space and creating ads for clients. International agencies, such as McCann, Lintas, and BBDO, have Saudi affiliates to advise on local market developments, media placement and ad improprieties.

Advertising infractions are rare, which seems to suggest that self-compliance is working rather well in Saudi Arabia. In the absence of clear and specific guidelines, companies have avoided provocative ads and take a conservative advertising approach.

### Some Caveats

An examination of the legal environment in Saudi Arabia has provided several insights. First and foremost, it is critical to ascertain whether advertising content is compatible with the Islamic religion and its laws. Since the latter are considered immutable, it is certain that the basic legal framework of Saudi Arabia in this respect remain unchanged. Respected as the birthplace of Islam, Saudi Arabia, has been committed historically to ensuring the compatibility of state regulations with Islamic law. As such, it profoundly influences the Islamic bloc and provides a legal model and reference for those Muslim countries (such as Pakistan and Malaysia) desirous of experimenting with similar systems.

Second, advice on provocative and unconventional advertising strategies and ads should be sought from religious authorities. Violations may result in instant alienation of a wide segment of the public. Since Saudi Arabia is a conservative society with strictly enforced religious standards, an ad acceptable there is virtually guaranteed acceptance in other traditional Muslim societies.

Third, as in many developing countries, written and specific legislation pertaining to the regulation and censure of ads is scarce in Saudi Arabia. Therefore, guidelines for advertising have to be drawn from the cultural orientation and commitment of the government on broader social issues, such as consumer safety and protection. Legislation on important emerging issues, therefore, may act as a leading indicator in forecasting potential changes in advertising regulation and content. In addition, the informal silent language of regulations has to be understood. For example, no law says the name of a princely family should not be used in promoting a product, but such a reference would be considered disrespectful and in bad taste.

Fourth, self-compliance seems to be working quite well in Saudi Arabia. Since complaints can reach high government authorities very quickly because of open forums, it is difficult for controversial ads to go unnoticed even though no one group monitors violations *per se*. Moreover, corrective advertising can be extremely costly as some firms have discovered.

Conformity to the environment may not guarantee the success of an advertising campaign in Saudi Arabia, but a systematic and informed approach can certainly improve the likelihood.

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